The Run Up

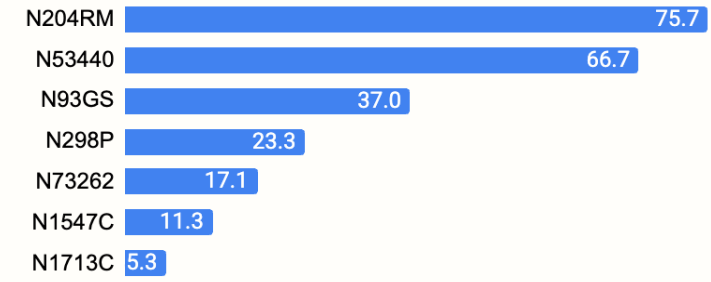
Information India | Airspacers Bi-Monthly Newsletter 👻 | September – October 2026

🍔 QUICK BITES

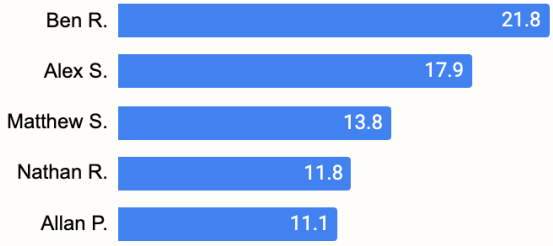
- **VOTE** for Santa Monica City Council Candidates. Consider supporting Lana Negrete, Ashley Oelsen, and Doug Trussler
- Airspacers is continuing to look for an entry-level leaseback! If you know anyone, or are considering buying one yourself, please reach out to the Board
- Hangar restoration project underway. If you'd like to donate any furniture, please reach out to **Mark Walker**
- Self-serve fuel project on hold due to steep insurance requirements. Thank you **Adam Handwerker** for doing all the research
- Flightbase.ai soft launch coming in November
- Signed leases for two tie-downs at VNY at The Park – see Member Website for map and details. Thank you VNY Captain **Danny Spivey**!
- SMO repaving project to begin in November – tie-downs not be impacted but hangar may be
- On behalf of all passengers, big thank you to **David Slone** for the generous Bose A20 headset donation. See locker contents on website
- **Adrian Santos** leading development of Airspacers Member Profiles – check your email for information about submitting info
- City has accepted SMAA's dolly proposal
- Airport Commission reappoints incumbent Diane Reynolds, though our own **Eve Lopez** was nominated by one councilwoman – the first-ever pilot nomination
- Operating Rules updated as of October 2026. See Member Website for details
- Q3 financial and operational update coming shortly – see Data Dashboard for details
- Congratulations **Elaine Mou** on purchasing a Cessna 140! 80th birthday party info on Discord
- Stay tuned for details about our Hangar Harvest in November

✈️ LEADERBOARD

Billed Hours by Aircraft (September 1 – October 31)



Active Pilots (September 1 – October 31)



⚒️ FLEET AND MAINTENANCE HIGHLIGHTS

- 262: In annual, watch mags, strobe light fixed
- 440: Oil temp sensor erratic on GI-275
- 98P: Overhaul scheduled for mid/late November
- 13C: Still grounded for Lycoming piston pin AD
- 3GS: Flying well
- 4RM: Flying well, range knob coming off
- 47C: Manifold pressure sensor replaced

📅 UPCOMING MEETINGS AND EVENTS

Member Meeting | The Six Chow House	Wed Nov 11
Hangar Harvest | Our Hangar at SMO	Date TBD
Member Meeting | The Six Chow House	Wed Dec 9
Holiday Party | TBD	Date TBD

FALL RECAP: COMMUNITY EVENTS, FLY-OUTS

Airspacers Board

It's been a busy fall season in the club – many ad-hoc member fly-outs, a WINGS lecture, some airport advocacy events, and a few new ratings.

Airport Conversion Community Conversation

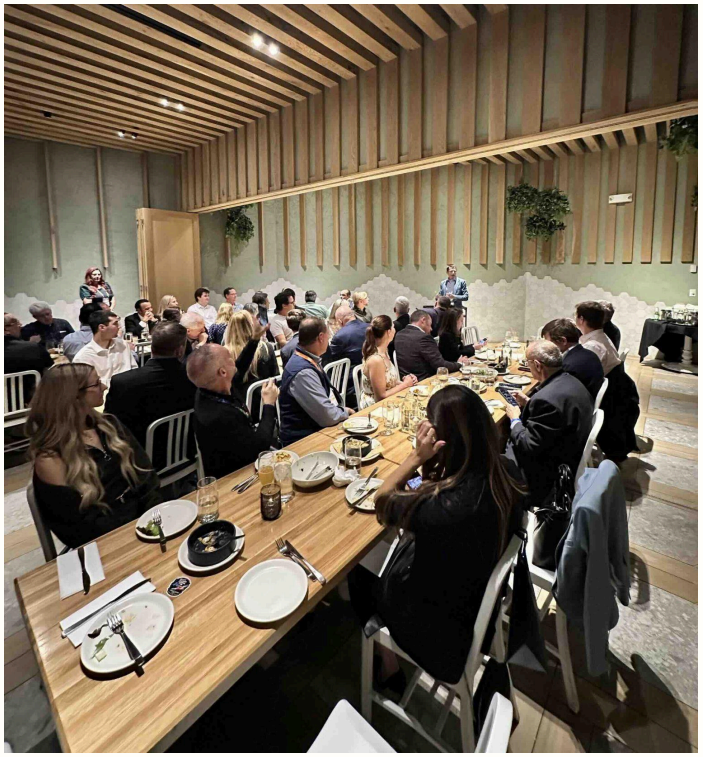
Members **Alex Silver** and **Elaine Mou** recently attended a community conversation about the conversion of Santa Monica Airport hosted by the City. Both the housing and "Great Park" coalitions were in attendance and the same talking points were on display. The fundamental questions of how the City will pay for a Great Park and how long the entire lot will sit vacant remain unanswered.



Airport conversion propaganda

National Business Aviation Association (NBAA)

Airspacers attended the annual Embattled Airports dinner at NBAA in Las Vegas in mid-October, along with other stakeholders on the field: SMAA, Santa Monica Flyers, and Sling. It was powerful connecting with folks from across the country whose airports are facing mounting political pressure to shut down, and learning about which strategies have been most impactful. Despite being referred to as being in "hospice care", we remain optimistic about the potential future of SMO.



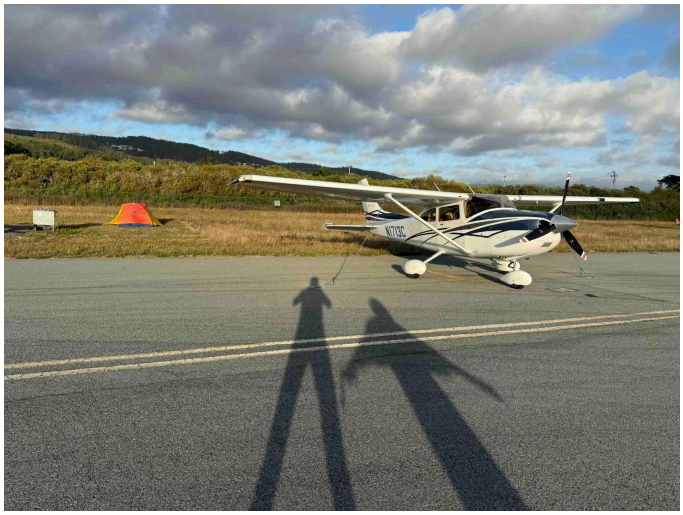
Embattled Airports dinner at NBAA 2026 in Vegas

WINGS / NOAA Event

Our Social Chairs organized a WINGS event with Andrew Rorke, Senior Forecaster at NOAA. The session covered practical weather insights and offered FAA WINGS credit for attendees. The content was gripping; not a single picture was taken.

Flyouts and Meetups

One of the best parts about Airspacers is unplanned, spontaneous fly-outs with fellow members. This fall, members flew all around LA, up and down the California coast and Central Valley, and northeast into the mountains/Sierras.



Members plane camping at Half Moon Bay (KHAF)



Alex Mandelberg *and passenger en route to Santa Cruz (KWVI)*



Nathan Richards, Alex Silver, Nick Katsinas, Ryan Haid, *and Toni Canonico at Tehachapi (KTSP) with Reno Air Race champion Bruce Lockwood (P-51 "Dago Red")*



Krisztina "Z" Holly *at the Lone Pine (O26) fly-in*



Ishan Shah *takes Ryan's family on a tour of downtown LA*



Ian Dutton, Josh Hinman, Shea Hovey, *and others on a spooky Halloween donuts and cider mission to New Cuyama (L88), an airport that Airspacers members have helped restore*

WEEKEND AT A FAMILY-OWNED FBO IN IOWA

Alex Silver, Hangar and 3GS Captain

Imagine a weekend cosplaying as an airplane mechanic, an FBO line worker, and a pilot with the plane selection of Harrison Ford (minus the mishaps). That sums up my weekend in Pella, IA, at Pella Municipal Airport (KPEA).



The Vande Voort family runs Classic Aviation, the FBO at KPEA. I met their family through a combination of mutual friends, social media, and airshows. Shane, the head of the family, is the airport manager, runs the flight school, oversees maintenance, is a CFII and a DPE, flies corporate… the list goes on and on. His wife, Megan, fills in the gaps and also serves as the event coordinator for Cirrus Owners & Pilots Association (COPA) University. They have two sons, Sullivan and Meyer — Sullivan is best known for soloing 13 planes on his 16th birthday. Suffice it to say, this family lives and breathes aviation.

When they invited me to check out their airport for the weekend, the answer was an immediate yes. On a Friday in early October, I flew Southwest Airlines into Des Moines (KDSM), where Megan picked me up and drove me into Pella. Pella is a historic Dutch town, known for its windmills and tulip festival. It reminded me a lot of Solvang, CA. Even the FBO has Dutch-style architecture and signage. From this first impression, I knew I was in a special place.

Upon arriving at the airport Friday afternoon, we got to work. We repositioned various planes to set up their 1940 Meyers OTW biplane for its annual inspection. Shane and Sullivan checked the seven cylinder heads of its radial engine, evaluated the control surfaces, and checked the oil. Meanwhile, Megan and I meticulously cleaned every surface, from the metal fuselage to the fabric wing surfaces. For a plane from the 1940s, the paint and surfaces are in pristine condition, so I took pride in making sure it came out of annual looking sparkly. The maintenance continued into the evening, sustained by a delivery from Megan and Meyer from a local pizza spot.



1940 Meyers OTW before Alex got to work

On Saturday, I woke up bright and early for a 7 a.m. “shift” with Sullivan working the flight line at the FBO. After our shift., we were ready to fly planes. The first plane was a 1946 Piper J-3 Cub, my first time in a Cub and my first ever tailwheel flight. Next, we hopped into their 1947 Stinson 108-2, a true retro plane complete with polished chrome instruments and stained wood finishes. We then did formation flying in their 1992 Vans RV-6, easily cruising over 200 knots. The afternoon wrapped up with the ultimate reward: taking the Meyers biplane up for a sunset flight. It’s hard to describe the bliss of seeing the fall foliage out of an unobstructed open-air cockpit. We landed back at the airport before dark, and tucked away all of the planes. We stayed in the shop through the evening to help prepare Cirruses for maintenance (oh, did I mention they are also a Cirrus Authorized Service Center?) Seeing the inside of the Cirruses brought the schematics of the POH to life, and gave me a stronger understanding of these planes, especially as a Plane Captain in the club. We worked long into the night, with Megan delivering brownies.

On Sunday, we took up their 1999 American Champion Citabria for my first aerobatic and first grass strip experience. We then took their 1946 Aeronca Champ to their sister airport Oskaloosa (KOOA), which is also managed by Classic Aviation. By around 3 p.m., it was time for me to head back to KDSM for my flight home. And just like that, my weekend in Pella was in the books.

Pella is an aviator’s paradise in the middle of the country, a strip of concrete amongst acres of corn and soybean fields. If it wasn’t obvious, it’s not just the airplanes that make Pella great… it’s the people too. The Vande Voort family as well as the full team at Classic Aviation could not have made me feel more at home and like a local. Every now and then in my aviation journey, I look for ways to reignite the flame of excitement. I think every pilot should get that flame rekindled, and if you’re looking for a place to find a spark, that place is Pella.

FUEL GAUGE VS. FUEL TOTALIZER: WHAT'S THE DIFFERENCE?

Ben Remy, Safety Chair

With the exception of 98P, we have fuel totalizers in every airplane in the fleet. I often hear from pilots that they don't totally understand what a totalizer does versus a traditional fuel gauge, and they don't really understand what each number on the screen means.

Fuel gauges (like the kind required for VFR day flight by 91.205) measure the quantity of fuel in the each fuel tank. In light airplanes like ours, this is usually done with float sensors. A float, made of cork, foam, or something similar, is mounted on the end of a pivoting arm and floats on top of the liquid fuel. Think of the float in your toilet tank! A sensor measures the angle of the arm to show you a gallon amount on your fuel gauge.

Fuel totalizers, on the other hand, estimate the amount of fuel remaining by taking a pilot's initial input and tracking fuel flow over time. The totalizer only knows what you told it, minus the fuel flow it measures over time. It does not measure how much fuel is left in the tanks.

There are pros and cons to fuel gauges and fuel totalizers, and they complement each other well.
Because a traditional fuel gauge measures liquid level, it can actually tell you how much fuel is in each fuel tank when you are straight and level, if it is calibrated and accurate. But when fuel sloshes around as you accelerate, decelerate, yaw, or roll, even the most accurate float-type fuel gauge can't get an accurate measurement.

On the other hand, a totalizer can measure fuel flow to the engine very precisely to give you a really useful, accurate estimate for how much fuel you have left, regardless of attitude or acceleration, but it has some important limitations to watch out for.
An accurate totalizer estimate is completely dependent on the starting number being correct. If the pilot inputs the wrong number, or if you trust the last pilot's input without verifying the fuel in the tanks during your preflight, the totalizer estimate will be wrong.

Another thing to keep in mind is that a totalizer only knows about fuel flow at the place where it is measured; it doesn't know if fuel is leaving the fuel system (i.e. leaking) anywhere else before that. If you leave the fuel caps open and fuel gets siphoned out of the wing, the totalizer won't know about it, but the fuel gauges will.

The best understanding of your fuel level in flight comes from using your fuel gauges and a fuel totalizer together, but however you keep track of your fuel in flight, the most important thing you can do is verify the fuel level in each tank during your preflight inspection.

Reach out to me or any of our instructors if you have any questions. Thanks for making safety happen every day!

📣 WELCOME NEW MEMBERS!

- **Jeremy Cofield** (Equity)
- **Mark Waldrep** (Equity)
- **Adam Handwerker** (Non-Equity)
- **David Zakariaie** (Non-Equity)

After more than 20 years, **Steve Savoldelli** is leaving the Club. Steve has been an active member of our community and we wish him well in this next chapter!

Interested in membership? Check out our website.

✅ RATINGS CORNER

- **Nathan Richards:** IFR
- **Josh Hinman:** Multi-Engine
- **Allan Parsons:** IFR



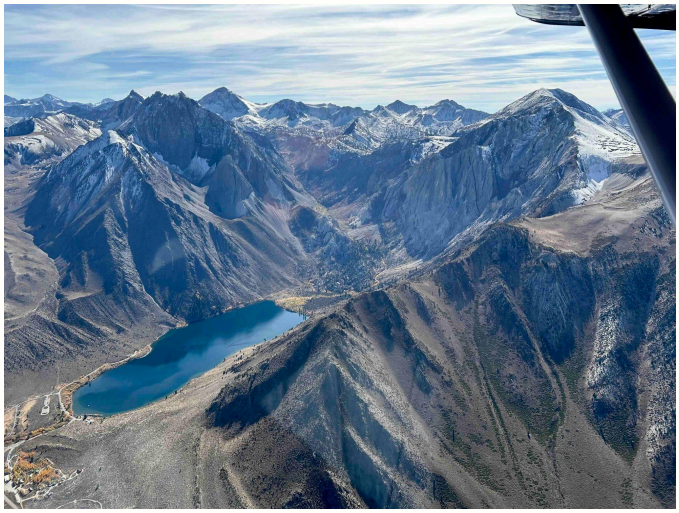
Nathan Richards with his IFR ticket in 440



Josh Hinman with his multi ticket

Congratulations Nathan, Josh, and Allan!

📷 VIEWS FROM THE COCKPIT



First dusting of snow in the Sierras at the Lone Pine fly-in



***Rahul Chandra** under the hood for IFR training*

ℹ️ ABOUT AIRSPACERS

Founded in 1958, Airspacers Flying Club is the oldest and most established flying club at Santa Monica Airport (KSMO), and one of the longest-running flying clubs in the greater LA area. Our mission has remained the same for over six decades: make the joy of aviation accessible, affordable, and community-driven.

We are a cooperative of 75 equity members, each an equal shareholder of Air-Spacers, Inc., the non-profit entity that owns and operates our aircraft, and an additional 30+ members across our Non-Equity, Social, and Leaseback membership tiers. Our fleet includes seven diverse airplanes, each suited for different styles and missions – available to any qualified member. To learn more, check out our website.

Have an idea for an article? Contact us. We're interested in covering news within the Airspacers and broader Santa Monica aviation communities.